

Sajag Network

A village-level scam early-warning system that works on any phone, in local language, by voice.

Seva First Innovation Challenge 2026 | Theme: Surakshit Bharat (Cyber Security) | Track A: Product / Technology
Submitted by: Tanmay Pondhe, Integrated M.Tech Software Engineering, VIT Vellore

One-line idea

Treat scams like an outbreak: when a scam hits one village, alert nearby villages in their own language, by voice or SMS, before it spreads.

The problem

Scam warnings today are national, generic and late. Police advisories and news reports mostly reach educated, online users. A first-time smartphone user, or someone with only a basic phone, often learns about a scam after a neighbour has lost money. Scams also spread in local waves, such as a fake challan APK or an electricity-cut message moving through one district.

[Add before submitting: 2 or 3 cited national figures on cyber-fraud losses and complaints, from I4C or cybercrime.gov.in. Use only numbers you can link to a source.]

What exists, and the gap

- **Scam checkers** (PhoneSathi, Scamy, ScamDekho, Scam Checker India, AI Scam Checker) help one person check one message, and need the user to open an app and type or paste.
- **Meta Scam Alert** flags likely scams on-device using patterns from reported conversations. It works per user, is optional, and is not aimed at local communities or low-literacy users.
- **Police and government advisories** are top-down, mostly text, and not local.

Gap: we found no system that turns individual reports into local, verified, voice-based alerts for people who cannot read or type well. The search was not exhaustive and should be repeated before final submission.

The solution

- **Report in one step:** a villager or helper reports a suspicious message, call or screenshot through any channel below. Sajag checks it and replies by voice in Marathi or Hindi.
- **Detect outbreaks:** when similar scams are reported in the same area within a short time, the system flags a local outbreak.
- **Verified alert:** a trained local moderator (college volunteer or panchayat staff) confirms it in one tap.
- **Alert on every channel:** nearby users and helpers get a short voice or SMS alert saying what the scam looks like and what to do. A simple dashboard serves panchayats and cyber cells.
- **Family guardian (optional):** a trusted family member can be told when an elder reports a scam.

Channels: one system, many doors

Channel	Who it reaches	How it works
Phone call (IVR)	Basic and feature phones	Give a missed call or call in, speak or press a number to report. The system calls back with a voice answer.
SMS	Any phone	Short local-language alerts, and reporting by SMS.

Channel	Who it reaches	How it works
WhatsApp	Smartphone users	Forward messages, screenshots or voice notes and get a voice reply.
Local helper	People using no digital channel	An ASHA worker, panchayat staff or college volunteer reports on their behalf.
Community broadcast	Everyone in the village	The panchayat shares confirmed alerts by loudspeaker, meetings or notice board.

All channels feed one report pool and one moderator queue. Alerts go out on whichever channel each person uses.

How a village is known: keypad phones have no GPS, so location is never fetched automatically. A village is identified either by pre-registration (a volunteer links each phone number to a village at enrollment) or by the caller's own keypad choice during an IVR call (for example, press 1 for Shivapur, 2 for Ambegaon). Smartphone users on the web app may optionally share GPS location with consent; this is not available to keypad users.

Why it is new

- **Community-level, not individual:** the unit of protection is the village, not the phone.
- **Works on any phone:** voice, SMS and helpers, not only smartphones.
- **Human-verified alerts:** prevents false alarms and rumours from spreading.
- **Local speed:** warns neighbours within hours, not after a news cycle.

Safeguards

Risk	Response
False alarms or rumours	A moderator confirms every alert before it goes out. Alerts state how many reports support them and never name people.
Privacy	Reports are anonymised. No phone numbers on the dashboard. Users consent before reporting.
Low trust	Local partners (panchayat, college, NGO) introduce the service.
Weak network or no smartphone	Voice, SMS and helper channels. Basic checks work offline.
Telecom rules	Confirm consent, DND and sender-registration requirements before bulk SMS or IVR.

Impact measures

Targets only. Replace the last column with real pilot data.

Measure	Target	Result
Pilot villages or wards	2 to 3	to fill
Users and helpers enrolled	100 or more	to fill
Scam reports received	50 or more	to fill
Time from first report to local alert	Under 24 hours	to fill
Users who finished a report without help	80% or more	to fill

Deployment plan

- **Weeks 1 to 3:** build the WhatsApp voice flow and moderator dashboard on the existing Sajag checker.

- **Weeks 4 to 6:** pilot with one college community and one nearby village through a panchayat or NSS unit; add SMS alerts.
- **Weeks 7 to 8:** add or design the phone-call (IVR) channel, measure results, and seek feedback from a district cyber cell.
- **Scale:** more districts and languages using the same volunteer model, with a shared alert feed for cyber cells.

Cost and support

- **Software:** low-cost hosting plus messaging, SMS and voice-call charges. [Add estimated Rs. per 1,000 messages and per call.]
- **People:** volunteer moderators keep recurring cost low.
- **Support wanted:** mentorship, pilot access to communities, and cybercrime domain guidance.

Prototype status and next steps

A working Sajag checker already analyses messages in English, Hindi and Marathi and runs on the phone with no data sent out. Next: the reporting and alert flow, the moderator dashboard and the pilot.

- Register by **5 October 2026**.
- Build the reporting, alert and dashboard flow.
- Run the pilot and record real results.
- Record a 2-minute demo: report a scam, see it on the dashboard, hear the Marathi voice alert.